

TEACH

UNIVERSAL

FOR ALL SIX PROFILES

The Drain Signals Field Guide

A guide to recognizing depletion early, in yourself and in teammates. **The signals arrive well before the burnout conversation**, for those who know what to look for.

THE DRAIN

Tertiary drain rarely announces itself; it accumulates. By the time it is visible as disengagement or exhaustion, it has been running for months. The early signals are specific and observable, but only if someone is watching for them with a framework in hand.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The guide catalogs the early signatures of sustained tertiary load: the behavioral tells, the quality patterns, the meeting-specific irritability that maps to orientation rather than mood. Read against a team's profiles, the signals become diagnostic, pointing not just at who is drained but at which work is draining them.

The early signals

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|---|---------------------------|--|
| 1 | Avoidance with a pattern | One category of task perpetually re-prioritized, while everything else moves. |
| 2 | Quality inversion | Errors appearing specifically in detail, follow-through, or framing, whichever matches the tertiary. |
| 3 | Meeting-type irritability | Fine in some rooms, visibly depleted in others. The room type names the drain. |
| 4 | Disproportionate recovery | A small task in the tertiary costing an afternoon of flatness afterward. |
| 5 | Language shifts | "I just need to push through" and its cousins, said about the same work, repeatedly. |

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 **Learn your own signature first.** Which two signals show up for you? Self-recognition is the entry point.
- 2 **Read teammates against their profiles.** The same behavior means different things in different wirings. The profile is the key.
- 3 **Name it as structure, never as character.** "That work is expensive for your wiring" opens a conversation. "You seem checked out" closes one.
- 4 **Route findings to the fix.** Signals lead to the Energy Budget, the Triage Tree, or the Trade Board, not to a pep talk.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

The guide reads energy patterns; it is not a wellbeing assessment, and sustained distress has causes far beyond work design that deserve real support, not a framework. Use the guide for what it sees, structural mismatch between wiring and load, and stay humble about everything else.

IN THE KIT

Signal reference sheet per profile

Self-observation log

Manager conversation guide

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 31 Energy Budget Planner · **Tool 43** Team Energy Audit · **Tool 33** Team Trade Board